Colour for your website and business

Yes, mainly where you sell craft, food and care. Brown promises a home base and authenticity, but can easily feel heavy.

In business, brown is a colour that **invites trust**, but at the same time carries a label of old-fashionedness. It can look honest, homely, natural and also luxurious. That is why it is good to know what you are promising before you let it into your logo, website or advert.

By itself, though, it **does not attract customers** like a magnet. It can help create a **distinctive impression**, but what still decides is mainly **what you sell**, **to whom** and **how well** it all works together.

What we are telling the customer

Brown can say, for example

"It's honest." "You are at home here." "It's from nature." "You can rely on it."

- **Craft and tradition.** Wood, leather, ceramics. Tradition can be alive, it does not have to look dusty.
- **Food and drink.** Coffee, bread, chocolate and baking. It links directly to the product.
- **Nature.** Brown paper can look simple and natural, but does not guarantee an ecological origin.
- **Home base and ease.** Earthy shades accompany a feeling of comfort, privacy and contact with natural materials.
- **Luxury.** Deep chocolate and leather brown can look exclusive if well executed.

Depending on the shade it also feels different. Caramel and honey are **warm and friendly**, beige and linen **calm and clean**, chocolate and chestnut **deep and serious**.

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Simple tips

Towards a lighter companion

Brown with cream and white looks lighter. Keep large areas light.

Show the real material

The grain of wood, a detail of hands, the surface of the product. A real story is usually more interesting than an artificial patina on everything including the price list.

Shade by role

Chocolate for depth, caramel for friendliness, beige for calm.

Legibility

Dark brown lettering on a similarly dark background is hard to read. Use a light background.

Cultural context

In India and in the army khaki is linked with uniform, in Norway with a home breakfast. Before you go out into the world, find out what brown means at home and where you are heading.

Colour blindness

About 1 in 12 men has difficulty telling red from green, and brown often changes in their perception. Do not rely on shade alone, add shape or text.

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Professions where it is a Yes

The rule is simple. When you sell a home base, craft or taste, brown can help you.

Café, bakery and chocolate

Here brown can link directly to the product, coffee beans, bread crust, cocoa. Give it a lighter companion and let real photographs stand out. When the packaging, background, table and cake are all brown, a visitor may spend a while looking for what to order.

Wood, ceramics, leather and craft

Brown here naturally links to the material and honest work. Show a detail of hands and the surface. Tradition can be alive and need not look dusty.

Body care, massage and stays

Earthy shades accompany a feeling of comfort and privacy. Make sure, though, that friendliness does not vanish in a dark or constantly beige whole. A person should see who will receive them, what you offer and how to book.

Outdoor movement, camps and outdoor sport

Brown with olive and green links to forests, trails and soil. For a sports brand it will need a sharper companion so that it does not look slow.

Professions where it is a No

This is not a ban for whole fields. What decides is the interplay of colour, text, photographs and setting.

- **Playful children's projects.** Brown alone may lack the variety you want to offer.
- **Projects built on lightness and freshness.** A heavy earthy tone may raise different expectations.
- **Long texts and important information.** Dark brown lettering on a dark background is hard to read.
- **Photographs of skin, food and art.** A brown filter can distort the real colours.
- **Dark waiting rooms and corridors.** More dark surfaces can strengthen a gloomy impression.

Try a striking shade in waiting rooms and rest areas first in a smaller amount.

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Before you send it out into the world

Show the design to a woman who does not know your offer and ask "What would you expect from such a place or service?" **Is the offer visible, or mainly the brown?** Her answer may tell you more than the general rule that brown means honesty and earthiness.

A question for you

“What should your customer feel first when she looks at your website?”

Examples from the market

You know brown from couriers and handbags. Here are **a few examples** that show what it can do.

- **UPS (logistics)**
  The founder James Casey originally wanted yellow vehicles. His partner Charlie Soderstrom objected that yellow is hard to keep clean and that Pullman railway cars are brown. Hence "Pullman brown". In the years after 2000 the company used the slogan "What can Brown do for you?"

- **Louis Vuitton (fashion)**
  The brand was founded by Louis Vuitton in Paris in 1854. In 1888 came the Damier canvas and in 1896 the Monogram canvas, which the company protected with patents worldwide. Brown became its quiet signature.

What they have in common is that brown carries a simple message. **Honestly, warmly, for use.** And it is mostly not everywhere, only where it should stand out.

Colours in business are not law. Studies are mixed and a lot depends on context, on customers and on how consistent the brand is. Take it as an idea to test, not as a rule. The brand examples are publicly known and the facts about them come from public sources.

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